

KF40 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Our physical goal for the **Three-Part Breath** meditation is to inhale and exhale for an equal amount of time, pausing at the end of each inhale and each exhale. This breathing method trains your mind to control your body’s reactions to fear and discomfort. It also gives you an opportunity to practice courage, endurance, and living in reality. During this training we will inhale for six counts of one second each, pause for three counts, exhale for six counts, and then pause again for three counts. If you find that you need extra air during this practice, go ahead and take a short inhale, and then return to the count. Continue to maintain a Mona Lisa smile and a relaxed perineum. When you find your mind wandering, gently say to yourself, “Release thoughts,” and then mindfully return to your breath.

To practice the **Three-Part Breath**, we inhale by first expanding the abdomen, then the lower ribs, and lastly the upper chest, stopping to pause just short of full capacity. On the exhale, first release the upper chest, then the lower ribs, and lastly the abdomen. Reserve a little air at the end of the exhale to bridge the pause before the next inhale. I will help you pace your breathing, for the first minute and then allow you to continue on your own for two more minutes. Are you ready? Let’s begin. *Inhale 2-3-4-5-6, pause 2-3, exhale 2-3-4-5-6, pause 2-3. (Repeat the count for 1 minute)* And now, practice on your own for two minutes. *(Pause for 2 minutes)*

Now return to relaxed and quiet breathing as you observe what is going on inside your skin. *(Pause 30 seconds)*

Open your eyes and re-engage with your environment and the meeting. *(Pause)* The **Three-Part Breath** massages your internal organs, expands your rib cage, and pumps your lymphatic system. By caring for your body, you teach it to trust you, and when your body can expect your care, it relaxes and begins to heal. As you practice the **Three-Part Breath**, you strengthen the power of your will and train your physical body to obey you. Your mind and body can then return to God’s natural order of authority in which we, as God’s creatures, cooperate with the True Self.

Our hymn for this month is *O Love That Will Not Let Me Go*.

O Joy that seeks me through the pain,
 I cannot close my heart to Thee;
 I trace the rainbow through the rain,
 And feel the promise is not vain
 That morn shall tearless be.¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?”)

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

Let’s be *makrothumos*² with ourselves as we work on KF Confession 9:

We learn to withdraw from the Idol Self and begin investing in our True Self.

You can learn to pause and ask before reacting to life’s events. Last week, I suggested using your **Flow Pages** to ask God about everything and, also, to explore a simpler life. Use your **Flow Pages** to list your questions and to tell God what you want. For years, I’ve made lists of wants and questions to help me explore and define my True Self. Whenever I look back at these lists, I am astonished at God’s creative ability to provide for me, often in unexpected ways, just because I asked.

When you simplify your life, you have more resources available for resisting the Idol’s chronic shoulds and claims. So, you might use your pages to explore what you do in a day and what might be motivating you. How much of what you do is driven by a should or a claim—by your Idol’s law and its fears? If you are a mastery type, your primary motivation is to win and to have everyone and everything under your control. If you are self-effacing, you are compelled to get caught up in other people’s business; you try to rescue them, merge with them, or play the victim. If you are resigned, you might feel driven to resist change or growth by engaging in unproductive and distracting activities. Whatever your neurotic development might be, you can explore this question: *What am I doing to achieve healthier outcomes in my own life and in the lives of others?* (Repeat) Hopefully, by now, no matter what your neurotic tendencies are, you can imagine a healthier outcome and take steps toward that goal.

Once you have asked God and identified the help that you need to simplify your life, you can begin adventuring. Adventuring is an exercise in humility and leads us to new levels of training and discovery, which change our self-perception and, consequently, our life experience. We start becoming something new. Becoming something new involves change, and change always reveals limitations. Our Idol won’t like that! It will react to your efforts to change and punish you with self-hate.

Change presents new challenges that will exercise both your humility and your courage. If you are committed to your pride system, doing new things and thinking new thoughts will be much more difficult for you. Pride hates to make mistakes or run into the limitations that adventure inevitably brings. That is why your Idol Self will be screaming at you when you start to break new ground. The good news is that God is eagerly waiting to extend to you His karis gifts when you courageously choose the humility of adventure.

If you force yourself and everyone around you to accommodate your comfort zone, you are simply

avoiding the fear and self-hate that come with exploring new territory. You will not find your True Self by remaining in your cozy cage of predictable misery. Adventuring means taking on new challenges and using new skills that you have acquired through hard training. Adventuring might also mean revisiting something that you have struggled with in the past, perhaps an area of failure or fear. It might mean reaching toward a goal without tested skills but with real courage and growing self-confidence. It might mean doing the KF program! By extending beyond your comfort zone, you discover more of yourself and more of God, and as a result, your trust in God's ability to care for you grows. This process of discovery builds the sustaining courage and self-confidence that you need to fulfill the potential of your created design.

A friend of mine recently did something for the first time. He took up the adventure with fear and trembling. He knew that he was in the good hands of God, but his Idol Self was shrieking, "You are going to look like a fool. People will know that you can't do this. You are only allowed to do things that make you look good. You will find out that you need training and have limitations. Your body will do something weird, and you will be so ashamed. What if you discover something about yourself that you don't like? You won't be able to keep the secret that you really are an untrained beginner. Why expose the truth about yourself? You are going to be so uncomfortable!" However, because he had trained hard and learned how to manage his self-hate, he was confident that he could overcome his resistance and gain the prize that oriented adventure offers.

Adventuring reveals your weaknesses, and knowing your weaknesses builds your self-confidence. When you know your weaknesses, you can learn to work around them and get help. In the gym or on the track, you discover your body's weaknesses through pressing toward the limits of your strength. This process of productive exhaustion strengthens your muscles. Your soul experiences a similar kind of exhaustion through adventuring. You get to explore your real and imagined weaknesses and can then make choices based on that evidence. Your soul's strength is matured through the process of managing and training those weaknesses. Once you understand this, you and God can work together strategically to develop your soul's potential. When you identify a weakness, get all the help you can to strengthen that weak area. Let me say that again. Get all the help you can to strengthen that area of weakness. Then, with the peace and security of a stronger soul, and with growing self-confidence, you can look forward to the next training opportunity, and cooperate with God, who is eager to prepare you for your next leap forward into real glory.

God opposes the proud, but He invites the humble into new depths of relationship with Himself.³ Rather than scrambling to achieve your Idol's imagined abilities, why not humble yourself, live within your real abilities, and let God do the glorifying? Admit that you don't know it all. Allow yourself to be trained and taught. Get help. Adventure into new things and honor the struggle that is an unavoidable component of growth. As the Idol's illusions are exposed, you will feel self-hate, but remember that your struggle with self-hate is also a natural part of progress. Humble yourself and admit that you are a beginner, just a little child who is preparing to inherit the kingdom of the heavens.

Our prayer might go something like this:

God of new things, show me the next adventure. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING**1:00 BIBLE TEACHING**

KF Confession 9 reminds us of the two choices that lead to orientation:

We learn to withdraw from the Idol Self and begin investing in our True Self.

In KF 37, we looked in the Gospel of Matthew at a famous passage where Jesus tells us to cut off the ways of seeing, the choices of action, and the predilection for paths that lead to misoriented and chaotic outcomes. We learned that we must become like little children, free from prideful illusions and fiercely single-minded in our efforts to grow into the people we were created to be. Next, we turned to Romans 6 where Paul teaches us how to withdraw from the Idol and invest in our True Self. Here is a review of what we have already learned in that chapter:

1. God will allow you to dawdle in misorientation until you die. The choice is always yours.
2. You can choose to plunge into the ultimate immersion course and learn how to live in a new country with Jesus. It's difficult, but very rewarding.
3. Through the gift of Jesus, your Creator has already invited you to take up your true life and pursue a relationship with Him. It's up to you to take the next step.
4. The fear of death has been overcome by Jesus, who conquered death. You are free to adventure without fear when you are connected to Him.
5. You were created to serve. You either serve God or your Idol Self. You cannot serve both. Whom will you serve?
6. Your physical body is a weapon whether you use it for God or for your Idol Self. How you use your body is your choice.
7. If you are a Christian, misorientation is no longer your master. You have been set free to offer your service to God as a karis gift.

Paul is trying to persuade you to turn away from serving the destructive nature of the Idol Self. He begins by invalidating your excuses for choosing to indulge the Idol Self and then reminds you that you build your character through your own choices. You can choose the path that leads to death, or you can choose the path that leads to a life of unimaginable peace, adventure, and blessing. God is for you—for the person He created you to be. He is not against His design. He really is promising to give you your true heart's desire. He is asking you to do the hard work of orientation for your own sake, for His sake, and for the sake of those you love. You can trust the process.

Let's finish our study of this chapter by reading my paraphrase of **Romans 6:19–23**.

¹⁹I speak as one human being to another because of the vulnerability of your Idol Self. You are used to standing beside the Idol, presenting your body as a slave to its muddy motivations and to the misorientation of compelling shoulds and claims, resulting in more misorientation. Now, in the same way, stand beside orientation as if you were its slave, with the result that you become an island of orientation, dedicated to God, surrounded by a sea of confusion. ²⁰Look at it this way. When you were slaves of misorientation, you were exempt from the work of orientation. ²¹And now, ask yourself, "What fruit was born from that slavery, doing those things of which I am now ashamed?" And, indeed, you should be ashamed because the outcome of those misoriented things is death. ²²But now

you have been freed from misorientation and are enslaved to God, and this is your fruit: you become an island of orientation in the sea of confusion, having an eternal quality of life, set free from the anxieties of a time-bound world that is passing away.²³ What you earn as a slave to misorientation is death, but, as a slave to Christ Jesus our Lord, you receive God's karis gift of eternal life, which invites you into deeper and deeper correspondence with Him.

Take a deep breath.

When we think of slavery, we often think of a system that forces people to use their own resources in the service of another with no benefit to themselves. We think of tyrants or masters who use threats, cruelty, and deprivation to motivate their slaves. In first century Rome, however, many slaves were considered part of the household. These slaves were motivated by reward, loyalty, and trust. Loyal slaves had a proprietary and often passionate interest in their master's honor because the master's honor was theirs.

As a slave of Jesus, we are safe and free to adventure, and if we remain connected to Jesus, we can adventure with courage and enjoy His support. Adventure requires some confidence or trust in a system or person. Our confidence to adventure is based either on the pride system of the Idol Self or on our connection to Jesus. Perhaps we are beginning to see that the Idol is a foolish and cruel master. We may feel afraid of slavery because slavery to the Idol is the only slavery that we know. We attribute to slavery all the powerlessness, vulnerability, and fear that we have experienced at the hands of the Idol. Paul's goal is to help us relax and thrive in the household of a new master. This new Master is training us to have the confidence and skills to take up the authority and responsibility of administering His kingdom, living lives that declare His excellence, reputation, and glory.

Whose slave will you be? Will you be enslaved to misorientation and produce fear and death, or enslaved to orientation and gain practical skills as well as honor, love, and the karis gift of eternal life? The choice is yours.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Jesus, my Master, I choose to be Your slave. Show me how. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your meditation posture, and breathe.
(Pause for 10 seconds)

Here is our integration focus: *Consider becoming the slave of Jesus. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

This may be a difficult focus for you. See if you can try it on for a few minutes during the integration.

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider becoming the slave of Jesus*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you may be experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

As you *consider becoming a slave of Jesus*, lightly hold your experience in your awareness without judging it as either good or bad. You might notice a compulsion to resist, to withdraw, or to capitulate. Just observe. *(Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body and notice what it is doing when you *consider becoming the slave of Jesus*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* You might say to yourself, “Oh, I recognize that feeling of relief,” or you might feel anxiety, irritation, or resistance in your body. You might feel nothing at all. As you consider becoming a slave of Jesus, gently focus your attention on whatever your body is experiencing. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider becoming His slave*. Is that prospect comfortable or uncomfortable, or have you shut down? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you feel compelled to judge this slavery as good or evil, or a mixture of both? What do you imagine such a life might be like? *(Pause)* Could you be experiencing fear—the fear of loss or missing out, or perhaps the fear of yourself or others? *(Pause)* Observe your experience as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

As you breathe, repeat the word *Welcome*. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

(Pause for 8 seconds or one long breath after each statement)

- Welcome this opportunity to explore your pride.
- Welcome the Holy Spirit of truth and His willingness to support you.
- Welcome your present reality and the progress you have made.
- Welcome what you are learning about yourself. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Now, as you breathe, you might use the following statements as a confession to the Lord and turn away from the Idol Self. On the exhale, let go.⁴

(Pause for 5 seconds after each statement)

- As I consider becoming a slave, I let go of the longing to have my own way.
- As I consider becoming a slave, I let go of the longing to be admired and respected.
- As I consider becoming a slave, I let go of the longing to be safe and comfortable.
- As I consider becoming a slave, I let go of the longing to fulfill my dreams. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,
Thank you for drawing us together for training and healing. Sanctify us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our real glory and to the truth of who You created us to be. Lead us into the next adventure this week as we co-labor with You to heal and to fulfill our design and mission for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

*New students are now registering for the NHG book study, and KF members are invited to sign up to help with facilitating at [NHG Facilitator Info](#).

*(*Except when preparing for the Jubilee Year)*

During the two-week period of Christmas and the New Year, the regular Karis Fellowships meetings will combine into one weekly mega-meeting. Check out the KF [Calendar](#) for the dates and times of these two meetings.

¹ *O Love that Will not Let Me Go* by George Matheson (1842–1906),
www.youtube.com/watch?v=sxcnEBn1nA0.

² See KF6.

³ James 4:6.

⁴ www.camillecaldwell.com/WelcomePrayer.html. Adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.